

WORK VISA IN UK

1.1. Overview

A Skilled Worker visa allows you to come to or stay in the UK to do an eligible job with an approved employer.

This visa has replaced the Tier 2 (General) work visa.

It also allows you to work in UK waters.

1.2. Eligibility Requirements:-

1.2.1. Your job

To qualify for a Skilled Worker visa, you must:

- work for a UK employer that's been approved by the Home Office
- have a 'certificate of sponsorship' (CoS) from your employer with information about the role you've been offered in the UK
- do a job that's on the list of eligible occupations
- be paid a minimum salary - how much depends on the type of work you do and the date you got your CoS

The specific eligibility depends on your job.

Skilled Worker Job Eligibility

You must meet all the following requirements to be eligible for a Skilled Worker visa:

- your job is eligible for this visa
- you'll be working for a UK employer that's been approved by the Home Office
- you'll be paid at least the minimum salary rate for the type of work you'll be doing

The minimum salary for the type of work you'll be doing is whichever is the highest of:

- £41,700 per year
- the 'going rate' for the type of work you'll be doing

The minimum salary may be lower if you're extending your Skilled Worker visa or updating it because you have a new job or employer.

Your employer must make sure your job pays at least the minimum wage and follows the UK rules for how many hours a week you work. If your employer does not do this, your application will be refused.

Check if your job is eligible

Before you can find out if your job is eligible, you need to know its 4-digit occupation code.

If you already have a job offer, ask your employer for your occupation code.

Look up your job's occupation code

If you do not know your code, you can search for your job in the [CASCOT](#) occupation coding tool.

Not every job title is included. If you cannot find your exact job title, try searching for similar jobs.

Make sure the job description matches what you'll be doing. Some similar jobs have different codes, for example in construction. Bricklayers, roofers and carpenters are eligible for a Skilled Worker visa, but construction labourers are not.

You must have a confirmed job offer before you apply for your visa.

1.2.2. Knowledge of English

You must be able to speak, read, write and understand English. You'll usually need to prove your knowledge of English when you apply.

You'll usually need to prove your knowledge of the English language when you apply. You can prove it in one of the following ways, by:

- having a UK school qualification

- having a degree from a UK institution
- having a degree from an institution that was outside the UK and taught in English
- passing an English test from an approved provider

If you have already proved your knowledge of English in a previous successful visa application, you may not have to prove it again.

If you have a UK school qualification

You can prove your knowledge of English if you have a qualification from a UK school that you began when you were under 18. You must have one of the following qualifications:

- a GCSE
- an A Level
- Scottish National Qualification level 4 or 5
- Scottish Higher or Advanced Higher in English

If you have a degree from a UK institution

You can prove your knowledge of English if you have a degree-level qualification that was both:

- taught in English
- awarded by a UK institution, even if you studied outside the UK

If you have a degree from an institution outside the UK

If your degree was taught in English and was not awarded by a UK institution, you'll need to apply for an assessment from Ecctis.

Ecctis will give you a code to confirm that your qualification is equivalent to a UK bachelor's degree or higher and was taught in English.

Passing an English test

If you do not have any qualifications that prove your knowledge of English, you will need to pass a Secure English Language Test (SELT) with an approved provider.

You must prove you can read, write, speak and understand English to at least level B2 on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR) scale.

1.3. Visa application fees

When you apply for a Skilled Worker visa, you'll need to have enough money to:

- pay the application fee - the standard fee ranges from £769 to £1,751 depending on your circumstances
- pay the healthcare surcharge - this is usually £1,035 per year
- support yourself when you arrive in the UK - you'll usually need to have at least £1,270 available (unless you're exempt)

You'll pay a lower application fee if your job is on the immigration salary list.

You'll be told how much you need to pay when you apply.

Example

You're applying to come to the UK from Argentina for 2 years on a Skilled Worker visa.

Your job is not on the immigration salary list so your visa will cost £769, plus £1,035 for each year of your stay for the healthcare surcharge. This means you'll pay a total of £2,839 when you apply for your visa.

You'll also need to prove you have £1,270 available to support yourself in the UK if your employer cannot cover these costs.

1.3.1 Application fees

If you're applying from outside the UK, the standard fee depends on whether you'll be in the UK for:

- up to 3 years - £769 per person
- more than 3 years - £1,519 per person

If you're applying from inside the UK to extend, switch or update your visa, the standard fee depends on whether you'll be in the UK for:

- up to 3 years - £885 per person
- more than 3 years - £1,751 per person

If your partner or child applies to join you in the UK, they'll pay the fee for the same length of time as you even if they apply after your visa has been granted.

Example

If your 5-year certificate of sponsorship expires in 2027 and your child applies to join you in 2025, they'll need to pay the application fee for more than 3 years.

1.4. Money/Funds to support yourself

You must have at least £1,270 in your bank account to show you can support yourself in the UK.

You will need to have had the money available for at least 28 days in a row. Day 28 must be within 31 days of applying for this visa.

You'll usually need to show proof of this when you apply, unless either:

- you've been in the UK with a valid visa for at least 12 months
- your employer can cover your costs during your first month in the UK, up to £1,270

Your partner and children will also need to prove they can support themselves while they're in the UK.

Read the guidance on financial evidence for more information about the money you need and how to prove it.

1.4.1. If your employer can support you instead

Your certificate of sponsorship must confirm this. Your employer will need to complete the 'sponsor certifies maintenance' section on your certificate. This is under 'Additional data'.

1.4.2. Types of funds you can rely on

You can show you have enough money using:

- a certificate of sponsorship (for some routes the sponsor must be A-rated to do this)
- a letter of endorsement if you're on the Start-up or Innovator routes
- your own money
- your partner's money if your partner is in the UK with permission or applying at the same time
- your parent's money if you're a child dependant

1.4.3. What fund evidence is not accepted?

The following are examples of what is not accepted as evidence to show you have the required amount of money:

- overdrafts
- bitcoin savings
- stocks and shares
- pensions
- bank accounts that are not regulated by the financial regulatory body in the country you're applying from
- bank accounts that don't use electronic record keeping

1.4.4. Control of the funds

You, or the account holder (such as your parents or partner), must have control of the funds you are relying on.

You must show the funds have been held for 28 days, unless you are relying on your sponsor or endorsing body.

The bank statement(s) or evidence you use to show the funds have been held for 28 days must be from the 31 days before you submit your application. The 28 days is calculated from the date of the last transaction in the last dated bank statement.

1.4.5. Funds Evidence you need to provide

If your sponsor is financially supporting you

Your sponsor will confirm that they have agreed to financially support you on the certificate of sponsorship you submit in your application.

If your endorsing body confirms you have funding

You must show an endorsement letter from the endorsing body confirming you have been awarded enough funds.

If you're using your own money

If you're not being financially sponsored, your funds can be held in any form of personal or building society account including a:

- current account
- deposit account
- savings account
- pension savings
- investment account

Cash must be in an account that allows you immediate access.

Funds must have been acquired legally and if you were in the UK you must not have earned them when working illegally.

If you're using your own money, or that of a parent or partner you'll need to show you have the required amount of money in an account. You can provide:

- bank statements
- building society passbooks
- certificates of deposit
- a letter from your bank or building society

Your bank statement should show information like:

- the date it was issued
- your name (or the account holders name if it is your parent or partner)
- the name of the bank or building society
- balance on the account

You can provide a download of electronic bank statements if it has this information. You do not need to have these stamped by the bank.

We may do verification checks with your bank. If we're unable to verify the funds your application may be refused.

Your bank must be regulated by the appropriate regulatory body for the country in which it is operating.

1.5. Documents you'll need to apply for work visa

When you apply you'll need to provide:

- your certificate of sponsorship reference number - your employer will give you this
- proof of your knowledge of English
- a valid passport or other document that shows your identity and nationality
- your job title and annual salary
- your job's occupation code
- the name of your employer and their sponsor licence number - this will be on your certificate of sponsorship

Ask your employer for a copy of your certificate of sponsorship if you do not have one.

Other documents you might need

Depending on your circumstances, you might be asked to provide:

- evidence that you have enough personal savings to support yourself in the UK, for example bank statements (unless your certificate of sponsorship shows your employer can support you)
- proof of your relationship with your partner or children if they're applying with you
- your tuberculosis test results if you're from a listed country
- a criminal record certificate - if you're working in certain jobs
- a valid ATAS certificate if your employer tells you that you need one because your job involves researching a sensitive subject at PhD level or higher
- your UK PhD certificate, or your unique Ecctis reference number if your qualification is from outside the UK - you'll need to apply through Ecctis

If your documents are not in English or Welsh you'll also need to provide a certified translation.

Criminal record certificate

You'll need to provide a criminal record certificate if you're applying from outside the UK and you work in:

- education, for example teachers, education advisers and school inspectors, childminders, teaching assistants
- healthcare, for example nurses, doctors, paramedics, managers, pharmacists, dentists and dental nurses, ophthalmic opticians
- therapy, for example psychologists, speech and language therapists, counsellors
- social services, for example social workers, managers, probation officers, welfare and housing officers

If you work in healthcare, you might be able to apply for the Health and Care Worker visa instead.

If you've lived in more than one country

You might need to provide a certificate from each country you've lived in, depending on your age and how long you stayed in each country.

If you're under 28, you'll need a certificate from any country you've stayed in for a total of 12 months or more since you turned 18.

If you're 28 or over, you'll need a certificate from any country you've stayed in over the last 10 years.

When you've got your documents ready

1.6. Apply online for visa

You can apply online once your documents are ready.

How you apply depends on whether you're:

- outside the UK and are coming to the UK
- inside the UK and extending your current visa
- inside the UK and switching from a different visa

1.6.1. Apply from outside the UK

You must apply online for a Skilled Worker visa.

Check which documents you'll need to apply.

Proving your identity and providing supporting documents

As part of your application, you'll need to prove your identity. How you do this depends on where you're from and what type of passport you have.

You'll either:

- use the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' app to scan your identity document - you'll also create or sign into your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account
- have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a visa application centre

You'll be told what you need to do when you apply.

If you do need an appointment:

- you'll need to take your passport with you to the visa application centre (you'll be able to collect it on the day)
- you may have to travel to get to your nearest centre (this could be in another country)

Apply for a Skilled Worker visa

Once you've started your application, you can save your form and complete it later.

How long it takes to get a decision

Once you've applied online, proved your identity and provided your documents, you'll usually get a decision within 3 weeks.

You'll be contacted if your application will take longer, for example because:

- your supporting documents need to be verified
- you need to attend an interview
- of your personal circumstances, for example if you have a criminal conviction

You may be able to pay to get a faster decision - you'll be told if you can when you apply.

After you apply

You can ask to cancel your application. You'll only get your fee refunded if UKVI has not started processing your application.

You'll get an email containing the decision on your application. This will explain what you need to do next.

1.7. Update your visa if you change job or employer

You'll need to apply to update your Skilled Worker or Tier 2 (General) work visa if:

- you want to change your job and your new job is with a different employer
- your job changes to a different occupation code, and you're not in a graduate training programme
- you leave a job that's on the immigration salary list for a job that is not on the list

You do not need to apply again if you stay in the same job, but your job is taken off the immigration salary list.

If you'll be doing a different job for your current employer, you only need to apply to update your visa if your new job is in a different occupation code.

If your new occupation code is listed as 'medium skilled', you can update your visa if both of the following apply:

- you got your certificate of sponsorship for your first Tier 2 or Skilled Worker visa before 22 July 2025
- you have continually held one or more Skilled Worker visas since then

Your partner or children will need to apply separately to update their visa. They can either apply at the same time as you, or at any time before their current visa expires.

1.7.1. Fees to update visa if you change job or employer

Check how much it costs for your type of visa.

You'll also need to have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken - there's no fee for this.

1.7.2. Eligibility and documents you'll need to apply to update visa if you change job or employer

Your new job must meet the eligibility requirements and you'll need a new certificate of sponsorship to prove this.

You may be able to meet lower salary requirements if both of the following apply:

- you got your certificate of sponsorship for your first Tier 2 or Skilled Worker visa before 4 April 2024
- you have continually held one or more Skilled Worker visas since then

You'll only need to provide other evidence again if you've been in the UK for less than one year.

If you're applying to add a second job to your current visa

You must apply to update your visa if you take on a second job that is more than 20 paid hours a week in addition to the job you're being sponsored for.

Your second job must meet the eligibility requirements and you'll need a new certificate of sponsorship to prove this.

If your second job occupation code is listed as 'medium skilled' you can add it if both of the following apply:

- you got your certificate of sponsorship for your first Tier 2 or Skilled Worker visa before 22 July 2025
- you have continually held one or more Skilled Worker visas since then

You'll also need to include a letter with your application explaining that you want to change your current permission to stay.

Your letter must state:

- your name
- your date of birth
- your current certificate of sponsorship reference number
- the date when your current permission to stay runs out

If your application is successful, you'll get a new visa giving you permission to do both jobs.

You do not need to apply to update your visa if you're taking on additional work that has an eligible occupation code or you'll be doing less than 20 paid hours a week.

1.7.3. When to apply to update your visa

You can apply to update your visa up to 3 months before the start date of your new job.

You can continue working in your current job while your new application is being considered, or to work out your notice period - as long as you apply before your current visa expires.

You should not start your new job until you've got confirmation of your new permission.

You must not travel outside of the UK, Ireland, the Channel Islands or the Isle of Man until you get a decision. Your application will be withdrawn if you do.

1.7.4. Proving your identity and providing supporting documents to update visa

As part of your application you'll need to prove your identity. How you do this depends on where you're from and the type of passport you have.

You'll either:

- use the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' app to scan your identity document - you'll also create or sign into your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account
- have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) service point

You'll be told what you need to do when you apply. You'll also be told how to provide your supporting documents if you need to.

1.7.5. Apply to update your visa

You must apply online.

Once you've started your application, you can save your form and complete it later.

1.7.6. How long it takes to get a decision for update visa

You'll usually get a decision within 8 weeks of your application date.

You'll be contacted if your application will take longer, for example because:

- your supporting documents need to be verified
- you need to attend an interview
- of your personal circumstances, for example if you have a criminal conviction

You may be able to pay to get a faster decision - you'll be told if you can when you apply.

1.7.7. After you apply for update

If you need to change something in your application after you've sent it contact UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI).

You can ask to cancel your application. You'll only get your fee refunded if UKVI has not started processing your application.

You'll get an email or a letter containing the decision on your application. This will explain what you need to do next.